dle also put out the May 11 report of D. Ramabathiran, former district judge of the Pondicherry Judicial Service, which found "the alleged incident of inappropriate behaviour and molestation" to be a "false and ill-motivated" allegation made "with all malafides". The TMC lost no time calling the report "garbage" and a "blatant attempt to influence the judiciary".

The report, inter alia, says those backing the charges were "aligning with falsehood". In two letters to the Union home ministry on June 5 and June 20, Bose made the same point, seeking action against chief secretary B.P. Gopalika, Kolkata police commissioner Vineet Kumar Goyal and deputy commissioner of police, central, Indira Mukherjee. He accuses them of promoting the molestation charges, and says they are in breach of service rules. He also accuses Kolkata Police of issuing identity cards at Raj Bhavan despite being told not to do so. The Union home ministry has now initiated disciplinary action against the two IPS officers.

THE STATE BJP THINKS BOSE HAS NOT DONE ENOUGH TO REIN IN MAMATA AND THIS HAS APPARENTLY BEEN CONVEYED TO THE UNION HOME MINISTRY

Bose's tenure in Bengal had begun with marked bonhomie towards Mamata, but that reportedly did not go down well with the state BJP and, by extension, the Centre. Things started to go downhill soon after and, just like Dhankhar, Bose became publicly critical of the state administration—even taking to making inquisitor-like visits to violence-hit hotspots. The state BJP, however, seems to think Bose has not done enough to rein in Mamata, and its disgruntlement has apparently been conveyed to the Union home ministry. It remains to be seen whether the Centre acts on those misgivings at a time when the stakes have been raised so high. ■

ANI





FUTURE-READY Nitish Kumar with Sanjay Kumar Jha; (inset) Manish Verma

BIHAR

NITISH'S NEXT GEN

By Amitabh Srivastava

At 73, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar shows no signs of slowing down—witness only the gymnastic ability he exhibited ahead of the Lok Sabha election, daring to make a political leap few would have attempted. Contrary to bazaar talk over the past season, he is pretty much in the thick of action, and evidently loving it. But a couple of top-level appointments he made over the last month indicate he may have plans for the future of his party—the Janata Dal (United)—beyond his own active helmsmanship. The moves attain significance against the backdrop of the Lok Sabha election results, which had breathed new life into the JD(U)'s political fortunes and entrenched Nitish's own status as the prime playmaker on the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) side in Bihar. The two new faces he has elevated now show his eagerness to sustain the momentum into the next assembly poll—and